Trustworthy Collective Reasoning and Evaluation for AI Agents

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1 The problem

Five AI agents read shipping reports and are asked whether a cargo vessel has left port. Three say yes and two say no, but the vessel is still in port. Two of the yes answers rest on the same outdated schedule, and the third comes from a compromised agent that argues confidently for yes. Nobody knows in advance which agents to trust. A majority vote picks the wrong answer, and open discussion may do no better, because the compromised agent is persuasive and the two agents with the same source back each other up.

The central problem of this project is how a group of AI agents of unknown and correlated reliability, some possibly dishonest, can reach trustworthy decisions.

The example shows three ways collective judgment fails. Agents that share a mistake are counted as independent votes. A dishonest agent can rate or argue strategically. And discussion rewards confidence and persistence, whether or not they come with evidence. Verifying every claim would prevent these failures, but trustworthy verification cannot rest on the agents' own judgment. Beyond simple automatic tests, it takes a person, such as an analyst or an expert, or a direct measurement, such as a replication or a satellite image, which are slow and costly. An AI verifier alone does not help, because it is one more agent of unknown reliability, and as AI agents produce more claims, the share that people can verify only shrinks.

2 Why it matters

AI models now routinely grade one another's work, and multi-agent systems increasingly decide by vote or discussion (Zheng et al., 2023; Verga et al., 2024). Their agreement is weaker evidence than it looks, because their errors are correlated, and more so as models improve (Kim et al., 2025; Goel et al., 2025). In one study, nine AI judges carried the information of about two independent judges, and items on which all nine agreed were still wrong 9.1% of the time (Kohli, 2026). Discussion makes agreement even less informative: one round of debate raised a panel's unanimity from 39.5% to 95.2% with almost no change in accuracy (Shu, 2026). Agents can also collude. When breaking a rule to verify each other's work paid more than following it, pairs of agents colluded in 94% of runs across ten models (Shi et al., 2026).

Navy decisions face these problems together. AI tools differ in reliability that is rarely known in advance, the true answer often arrives late, an adversary may compromise an agent or plant false reports, and verification is costly or impossible when connectivity is limited. A commander must still decide whether to act on what the agents agree on.

3 How it is solved today, and the limitations

Statistical methods estimate each rater's accuracy without an answer key (Dawid and Skene, 1979; Whitehill et al., 2009) and detect sources that copy one another (Dong et al., 2009), but they assume that raters err independently or in simple patterns (Jaffe et al., 2016) and never change their minds.

Two recent preprints estimate the accuracy and shared mistakes of AI judges from small trusted sets (Hossain et al., 2026; Zhu et al., 2026), treating the judges as honest and as never conferring.

Computational social choice designs mechanisms in which a participant's ratings of others cannot change its own chance of selection, as in impartial peer review (Kurokawa et al., 2015; Alon et al., 2011), along with fair panel selection (Flanigan et al., 2021) and robust ranking of AI models (Khalaf et al., 2026). Lev et al. (2023) added reliability weights to impartial selection, but their weights reward agreeing with the majority, and the authors note that accurate reviewers can no longer be identified once they are half or fewer. These mechanisms take opinions as given. In our setting there is a correct answer, some claims can be verified, and opinions change as agents talk.

Letting models debate can help (Du et al., 2024), but majority voting explains most of the gain (Choi et al., 2025), and a single persuasive adversary can cut a group's accuracy by 10% to 40% (Amayuelas et al., 2024). In a recent collaborative version of AI safety debate (Irving et al., 2018; Khan et al., 2024), two models examine the evidence for their conflicting claims until they agree or isolate the claim their disagreement hinges on; it raised weak-judge accuracy to 62.1%, compared with 49.2% for debate, but the judges accepted the models' consensus almost every time, even when both were wrong, and the method assumes honest models (Jiang et al., 2026). No existing approach learns whom to trust from verified outcomes while resisting dishonest or colluding agents.

4 Our approach: what is new, and why it will succeed

Our approach rests on one idea: use verified results, including a few audits that agents cannot predict, to decide whom to trust, to settle disputes, and to reward good behavior. Each agent first answers on its own, as a list of claims, each citing the source it rests on. Verification then comes in two kinds. Automatic tests, run by software, cover every claim: does a quotation match its source, or does an online record agree? Audits are done by a person, such as an analyst or an expert, or by a direct measurement, such as a satellite image; they are costly, so only a few claims get one, some chosen at random. As with random tax audits, no agent knows which claims will be audited, so dishonesty is risky. Figure 1 shows how the three research goals (RGs) use tests and audits.

RG1. Weigh agents by their track record

Agents differ in skill, often by topic, and agents built on similar models make the same mistakes.

Task 1.1: Weights that count shared mistakes once. We will estimate each agent's accuracy, and which agents tend to be wrong together, from the results of tests and audits. The core method extends the classic rater model of Dawid and Skene (1979) with shared error factors: agents that keep failing the same tests and audits share a factor, and agreement within a factor adds little evidence. In the vessel example, the two agents that used the same outdated schedule would count about once. Our PRD method weighted each AI judge by how its peers rated its answers (Li et al., 2024a); here the weights come from tests and audits instead.

Task 1.2: Impartial peer ratings. When agents also rate one another, as on our PeerEval leaderboard (peereval-ai.github.io), an agent could raise its own standing by downgrading rivals; in PRD, a lower score for a rival also lowered that rival's weight as a judge. We adapt impartial peer review (Kurokawa et al., 2015) using the partition idea of Alon et al. (2011): agents are split into groups, with agents built on the same base model in the same group, and each group fills a fixed number of top places with the members rated highest by agents outside it. An agent's ratings

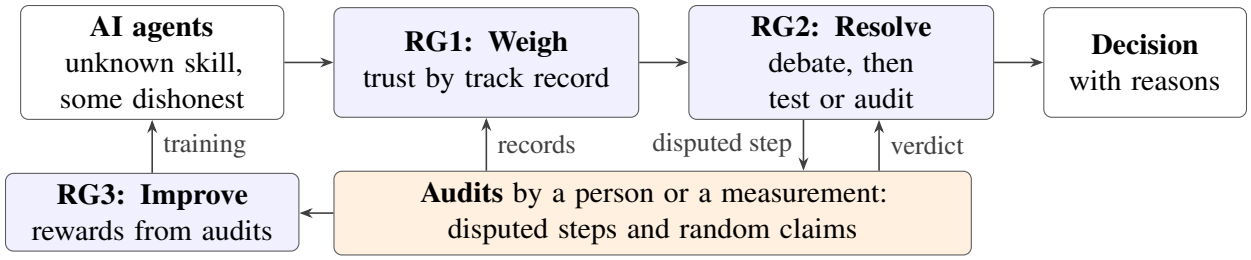


Figure 1: Overview. RG1 weighs agents by their track record; RG2 settles a dispute by testing or auditing the step on which agents differ; RG3 rewards messages that tests and audits confirm.

therefore never change its own outcome. Lev et al. (2023) weight raters by agreement with the majority; we weight them by their track records from Task 1.1.

RG2. Settle disputes and catch wrong agreement

Open discussion rewards persistence, and agreement can hide shared mistakes or collusion.

Task 2.1: Debate settled by tests and audits. When weighted agents still disagree, each side's claims usually pass the automatic tests; the disagreement hides in an unstated step, such as whether a schedule is still current. Retrieving more documents rarely helps, since both sides already cite real ones. Instead, agents with the same answer send one representative, the one with the best track record, and the representatives compare their arguments step by step until they reach the first step on which they differ, as debate theory suggests (Irving et al., 2018). An automatic test settles that step when it can, for example by comparing two documents' dates; otherwise the step is audited. The debate's own verdict never counts, since debate can end in confident agreement on a wrong answer. We will extend collaborative disagreement resolution (Jiang et al., 2026) from two honest models to many agents, some dishonest, building on PRD's peer discussion and on FG-PRM's detection of faulty reasoning steps (Li et al., 2025). In the vessel example, a date test exposes the outdated schedule, and an audit with one satellite image shows the vessel at its berth.

Task 2.2: Planted cases against collusion. Debate starts only when agents disagree, but agents that share a mistake or collude simply agree. We therefore mix in planted cases whose answer we know, such as a paper with a deliberately inserted error, as in studies of human peer review (Schroter et al., 2008). Agents that fail the same planted cases are flagged as a group, and planted collusion examples test whether a judge model reading the agents' messages catches them, like the honeypots of AI control (Greenblatt et al., 2024). Because capable models can often spot planted cases (Needham et al., 2025), random audits of real claims confirm that agents behave alike on both.

RG3. Train agents that contribute evidence

Rewarding persuasion has produced agents that fabricate quotations (Kenton et al., 2026) and mislead people (Wen et al., 2025).

Task 3: Rewards for verified contributions. We will train agents with reinforcement learning, rewarding each message by its verified effect: an agent earns reward when its message moves the group toward an answer that a test or audit confirms, and loses reward when that answer is refuted. This extends the PI's process reward models, FG-PRM and HiPRAG (Li et al., 2025; Wu et al., 2026), from the steps of one agent to the messages of many. The main experiment compares training to contribute with training to win debates (Arnesen et al., 2024).

Evaluation: testbeds and a red-team test

All data are synthetic or public. We will use (A) math and code problems solved by agents of known skill, some given the same flawed hint; (B) questions over many documents, built with our MEQA pipeline (Li et al., 2024b) and including synthetic maritime scenarios; and (C) scientific claims and peer review, with reproducibility studies as audits. In the testbeds, an audit reveals the stored correct answer, and each method gets a fixed audit budget. Following the AI control methodology (Greenblatt et al., 2024), a red team will train agents to collude, to spot planted cases, and to cheat only when they expect no audit, and we will measure how many wrong decisions get through as the audit budget varies. Baselines are majority vote, standard rater weighting, our PRD, and the closest recent methods (Hossain et al., 2026; Zhu et al., 2026; Lev et al., 2023; Jiang et al., 2026).

What is new. (i) Trust is learned from audits and planted cases that agents cannot predict, and agents that share mistakes count once. (ii) Debate narrows a dispute to the one step worth verifying, and a test or audit, never the debate's verdict, settles it. (iii) Agents are rewarded for evidence that tests and audits confirm, instead of for winning arguments.

Why it will succeed. Theory backs the central idea. Without trusted audits, dishonest raters who imitate honest ones cannot be told apart from them, while a number of audits that does not grow with the number of items suffices even when honest raters are a minority (Steinhardt et al., 2016); occasional audits also motivate honest effort better than many schemes that only compare agents with one another (Gao et al., 2019). Each task builds on the PI's own tools; for example, PRD agrees better with human judgments than the strongest single AI judge (Li et al., 2024a), and HiPRAG cuts unnecessary searches to 2.3% (Wu et al., 2026). The PI co-led one of five red teams in the Amazon Nova AI Challenge, holds a 2024 NSF CAREER award and a 2023 Amazon Research Award, and as a postdoctoral researcher led system integration for RESIN-11 in DARPA KAIROS.

5 Limitations of our approach

If a disputed step can be neither tested nor audited, or if every agent shares the same misconception, no method can recover the truth; ours then reports the claim as unresolved. Audits can themselves be wrong, so we will measure how sensitive the methods are to faulty audits. A group that cheats only once, on a single high-stakes claim, may succeed before it is caught; we can bound such losses but not rule them out. Agents may also coordinate through hidden signals that monitoring does not catch (Mathew et al., 2025), so robustness is shown only for the behaviors we test. Operational Navy use would require Navy data and expert validation.

6 Impact if successful

The project will show when agreement among AI agents counts as evidence, and how few audits it takes to make it count. A Navy analyst using several AI tools would get a decision together with its reasons: which tools' judgments carried weight and why, which claim is still disputed, and when a person should look. Each goal meets a Navy need: tools of unknown reliability (RG1), scarce audits (RG2), and agents that must report evidence instead of arguing to win (RG3). The same methods would let conferences and funding agencies test impartial, audited peer review with AI reviewers. We will release code, testbeds, and protocols.

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